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NYC Doesn't Fly Confederate Flags, But It's Still A Shrine To Slaveowners & Slave Profiteers¹

BY NATHAN TEMPEY
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In the weeks since white supremacist² Dylann Roof murdered nine people in a South Carolina church, there has been much public outcry³ about America's racist history. Activists, politicians, and everyday anti-racists are working to remove Confederate flags and monuments from public places. The campaign is a noble⁴ one—the flag was, after all, created for Southern white people to start a war to keep slavery, and the KKK often hold up the flag as a symbol of white supremacy—but for some liberal New Yorkers, it has served as a misguided⁵ reminder that the South is a uniquely racist place with a disgusting past that has nothing to do with them.



Of course, the problem with this type of thinking is that the whole country was built on slavery, not just the South. We have yet to deal with its horrors in any serious way like, for example, South Africa. South Africa has faced apartheid⁶, or Germany has accepted responsibility for the Holocaust⁷. Today, Americans can visit a national Holocaust museum in their own country, but not a national slavery museum.

An 1895 Harper's New Monthly article described slavery as "part and parcel of [colonial New York's] economic organization," and at one time New York was home to the most slaves of any city except Charleston, SC. Yet, it wasn't until last month that Wall Street got a marker memorializing the local slave market. At this market from 1711 to 1762, potential slave buyers made enslaved men flex their muscles to check their strength and grabbed women's genitals when considering a purchase. The African Burial Ground near City Hall didn't get a memorial until 2010, and it almost didn't get one at all because the developer building a tower on top of it tried to breeze through the regulatory process without acknowledging the site's historical significance. Few other reminders of this past exist in New York.

Monuments to prominent slave owners from New York's history, on the other hand, are plentiful, though they're seldom presented as such. For example:

James De Lancey (1703-1760), lieutenant Governor of New York and provincial Supreme Court judge. Delancey Street is named after him. He presided over the 1741 trials of dozens accused in a supposed slave revolt plot. One hundred fifty-two enslaved and free people of African ancestry, plus a handful of Europeans, were arrested, of whom



¹ Profiteers: People who make money unfairly, often by exploiting others

² White Supremacist: Someone who believes white people are naturally better than all other people

³ Outcry: when someone calls attention to an issue

⁴ Noble: something/one that is respectable and honorable

⁵ Misguided: Mistaken or wrong

⁶ Apartheid: A policy that separated people in public and private spaces based on race

⁷ Holocaust: the mass murder of Jewish people under the German Nazi rule from 1941–45

13 black men were burned at the stake, 21 people hanged, 84 sold into slavery, and seven exiled from New York. Historians now doubt that a plot existed in the first place.

Cadwallader Colden (1688-1776), colonial governor. PS 214 the Cadwallader Colden School in Flushing is named after him. He sold his slave Gabriel to keep him apart from the enslaved woman Gabriel was in love with. He also sold a 33-year-old woman and one of her children to someone in Barbados, because to allow her to be near the rest of her enslaved children would "spoil them."



CADWALLADER COLDEN.

The Van Cortlandts. Van Cortlandt Park is named after Stephanus Van Cortlandt, and the Westchester towns of Cortlandt and Cortlandt Manor are named after the family.

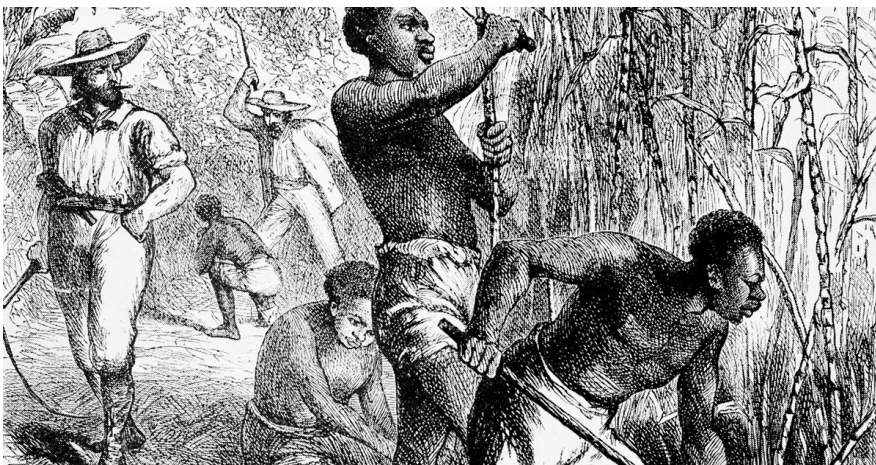


Olof Van Cortlandt came to the city in 1637 as an employee of the Dutch West India Company, a leading African slave trader that brought the first enslaved Africans to New Amsterdam, as the city was then called. His son, Stephanus was New Amsterdam's first locally born mayor. Stephanus's grandson Pierre brought slaves to staff the family manor. The family owned vast tracts of land in what is now Westchester County, and operated sugar refineries that processed slave-picked sugarcane. New York state abolished slavery in 1827, but trade in slave-made goods remained a staple of the local economy and wealthy and powerful city leaders continued to reap huge profits from the institution.

Moses Taylor, founder of the bank that is now Citibank, who traded in slave sugar. Investing in the slave trade and slave production allowed Citibank to grow into one of the world's largest banking institutions.



William Havemeyer owned what was eventually called the Domino Sugar factory. It refined sugar cane cut by slaves into sugar and molasses. Havemeyer Street in Brooklyn is named after him.



John Jacob Astor made his fortune trading fur, slave cotton, and for a time, opium. The Waldorf-Astoria hotel chain, Astor Place, Astoria, Queens, and a host of other New York places are named after his family. At the time of his death in 1848, Astor was the wealthiest person in the United States, leaving an estate estimated to be worth at least \$20 million, equivalent to \$655 million today.



The Lehman brothers Henry, Mayer, and Emanuel founded Lehman Brothers in 1850 as a slave-cotton brokerage in Alabama, then moved it to New York in 1870, post-emancipation. **Lehman College** in the Bronx was named after the family.

Still don't see it? How about this: **New York itself** is named after England's James II, Duke of York, who headed the Royal African Company, formed specifically to supply Virginia planters with captive labor.

We could keep going.

The very name "Wall Street" is born of slavery, with enslaved Africans building a wall in 1653 to protect Dutch settlers from Indian raids. This wooden fence, later known as Wall Street, became the home of world finance. Enslaved and free Africans were largely responsible for the construction of the early city, first by clearing land, then by building a fort, mills, bridges, stone houses, the first city hall, the docks, the city prison, Dutch and English churches, the city hospital and Fraunces Tavern. At the corner of Wall Street and Broadway, they helped erect Trinity Church.

Enslaved and free people of African descent struggled for liberation in New York, too, as they did throughout the South and the Americas. We may not think about slavery as we move through New York in our day-to-day lives, and there are few reminders, but tributes to its beneficiaries are inscribed all around us.